

West African Peanut Stew Dinner (Maafe) — 2× Batch

Sunday 13 September 2026 · 3 pax served + reserve

Menu

- 1. Chicken Peanut Stew with Kabocha & Okra — 2× batch
- 2. Steamed Rice
- 3. Tomato–Cucumber Lime Salad
- 4. Bird's Eye Chilli Paste
- 5. Crushed Roasted Peanuts
- 6. Chilled Pineapple with Lime & Flaky Salt

Dishes 2–6 carry forward unchanged and are sized for the served meal only. They are not scaled with the stew — salad and pineapple degrade within a day, and peanuts soften on contact with moisture.

Before You Shop — Vessel Capacity

The doubled stew needs 6–7 L working capacity. Measure the wide Le Creuset. If it is under 6 L: sear in the wide Le Creuset for the surface area, then transfer to a stockpot for the braise.

Either way, keep the 1.5 L + 300 ml stock architecture. A correction reserve costs nothing; removing water from a peanut stew is hard.

Workflow Notes

Critical path: Kabocha entry → kabocha cue / heat termination → lime + cilantro → plating → service. Okra and spinach nest inside that sequence. The strategy is early completion plus a safe submerged hold on the chicken, and cue-terminated heat on the kabocha — neither endpoint can be scheduled to a fixed minute, so neither is. Four cues govern the cook: chicken (flesh separates cleanly from the bone under firm thumb pressure), kabocha (knife tip enters the centre with slight remaining resistance — this one stops the heat), okra (yields to pressure, retains snap at the seed line), and lime (added off heat in 5 ml increments against kabocha sweetness).

What yields to what: Stew texture → kabocha texture → okra texture → rice → salad → condiments → pineapple. Do not delay service for any other component. If the kabocha cue fires while the okra is still firm, take the pot off heat anyway — firm okra is serviceable, over-tendered okra is not. Heat: Burner 1 owns the stew for the full cook; Burner 2 owns the rice from T-40 to T-12, then goes off. No oven, so no temperature transitions and no concurrent heat conflict. Everything except the stew runs in parallel during the T-45 prep block.

Reserve architecture: The reserve is chicken and peanut-tomato sauce only, diverted before any vegetable enters and before spinach, lime, and cilantro. Squash and okra are poor candidates for freeze-thaw texture, spinach degrades markedly on freeze-thaw, and lime brightness dulls in storage — all four are rebuilt fresh on reheat.

Holding Chain

Component	Hold Strategy	Max Hold	Drift & Corrective
Stew — chicken phase	Very low, covered, submerged	15 min	None — thighs hold well submerged
Stew — served, after cue	Off active heat	10 min	Tightens — hot stock, 50 ml increments
Stew — reserve	Shallow containers ≤5 cm, loosely covered → fridge	3 days fridge / 3 months freezer	See food-safety checkpoint, Dish 1
Rice	Covered, off heat	25 min	15 ml water, re-cover, re-fluff
Salad	Room temperature	30 min	Drain pooled liquid; re-season lime + salt
Chilli paste	Ambient, covered	4 hrs	None
Crushed peanuts	Dry bowl	Stable	None
Pineapple	Chilled	2 hrs	Re-dress with lime before serving

T-Minus Timeline

Total run approximately 2 hours.

Time	Task
T-115	Sear batch 1 — 4–5 min skin-side down, 2 min flip
T-107	Sear batch 2 — same. Remove all chicken; strip skin, discard
T-99	Aromatic base — onions + 4 g salt, 8–10 min

Time	Task
T-89	Garlic + ginger — 1 min
T-88	Tomato paste — 3–4 min to darken
T-84	Bloom spices 30 sec; crushed tomatoes 4–5 min, scraping fond
T-79	Add 1.5 L stock (hold 300 ml back); bring to low simmer — 6–8 min
T-71	Temper peanut butter with 240 ml hot liquid; return slowly, stirring
T-68	Chicken returns. Braise begins — low, partially covered
T-45	Prep block: cut kabocha, trim okra, salad, chilli paste, peanuts, pineapple
T-43	First chicken check (25 min mark). Re-check every 5 min. Once the cue is met — expected T-43 to T-33 — immediately reduce to very low, cover, and hold submerged until T-28
T-40	Start rice — 12–15 min very low, then 10 min rest covered
T-28	Divert reserve — half out, chicken and sauce only, no vegetables
T-24	Kabocha into served half. Begin checking after 12 min. Its cue, not the clock, controls when the stew leaves active heat
T-16	Okra into served half
T-12	Rice rest ends
T-8	Spinach in — unless the kabocha cue has already fired , in which case add spinach immediately off heat and let residual heat wilt it
T-9 to T-4 expected	Kabocha cue → pot off active heat immediately
Off heat	Lime in 5 ml increments, tasting between. Then cilantro, reserving some for plating
T-2	Plate rice and stew
T-0	Garnish with peanuts and reserved cilantro; serve

Plating window is 3–4 minutes from first plate to service. If it is missed, the stew temperature drops first, then the rice surface dries. Serve the salad alongside, within reach at every setting — it is interleaved with stew bites, not a separate course.

Timeline Verification

Chicken. Enters T-68, first check T-43 at the 25-minute mark. Band completion T-43 to T-38; worst case T-33 with the +5 min recovery invoked. Diversion at T-28 leaves 5 minutes of slack at the far edge, 15 at the near edge.

Kabocha. Enters T-24, band 15–20 min, checked from T-12. Cue expected T-9 to T-4. Earliest edge gives 9 minutes off active heat before service, inside the 10-minute served-stew ceiling. Latest edge leaves 4 minutes to kill the heat, adjust lime, add cilantro, and plate from T-2. Closes at both edges.

Rice. T-40 start, rest ends T-12, held 10 minutes against a 25-minute ceiling.

Okra — stated, not closed. Enters T-16 with a 10–12 minute band, but the kabocha cue terminates active heat somewhere between T-9 and T-4. Okra therefore gets 7–12 minutes active plus 4–9 minutes residual in a pot that keeps cooking off the burner. Residual heat brackets the gap at both ends, but this does not close arithmetically. Moving okra earlier to guarantee the earliest edge would hand it 17 minutes at the latest edge — straight into the over-tendered failure. Under the stated failure priority, okra yields to kabocha and firm is the accepted outcome.

On the day: if the kabocha cue fires at T-9, the pot comes off heat as the spinach goes in and residual heat wilts it. If at T-4, the spinach has already had its time. Both are fine. What you must not do is hold the pot on active heat waiting for T-0.

Meal Balance Audit

Richness comes from peanut fat and chicken and is the dominant axis. Relief is carried by the salad's acidity mid-meal and the pineapple's cold acid at the close.

Sweetness stacking is this version's specific risk. Kabocha, peanut butter, and pineapple all contribute.

Relieving elements: Stage 2 lime working harder than in the original, okra's vegetal note, and the salad's raw acidity. Watch this at the finish — it is the most likely place the meal drifts from the 9.5 baseline.

Heat is entirely externalised to the chilli paste, which is what lets one pot serve all three.

Acid appears in four components, all lime. Intended as functionally distinct — corrective brightness in the stew, between-bite reset in the salad, heat-carrier in the paste, closing cleanse on the pineapple. Whether four lime hits read as monochromatic in the eating is an open question. Observe and record. If it reads lime-dominated, the salad is the better place to switch: red wine vinegar gives a different acid shape.

Texture runs tender chicken → intact kabocha → okra snap → soft rice → crisp salad → peanut crunch → cold yielding fruit. No monotony risk. Register: comforting and generous.

Shared Prep

Limes: juice 3 limes (approx. 90 ml total)

- 15–22 ml → Stew finish
- 22 ml → Tomato–Cucumber Salad
- 10–15 ml → Chilli paste
- 15–22 ml → Pineapple

Garlic is deliberately not aggregated. The stew takes 8 cloves minced; the chilli paste takes 1 clove rough-chopped for pounding. Different prep treatment, kept separate.

Nothing else appears in two or more components in a form that can sensibly be prepared in aggregate. Onion and shallot are different items; the salad's red onion is a third.

Shopping List

Ingredient	Total	Stew	Salad	Chilli	Other
PROTEIN					
Chicken thighs, bone-in skin-on	2 lb 10 oz – 3 lb 1 oz / 1.2–1.4 kg	all	—	—	—
PRODUCE					
Bird's eye chillies	4–6	—	—	4–6	—
Cilantro	$\frac{2}{3}$ oz / 20 g	20 g	—	—	—
Cucumber	1 medium	—	1	—	—
Garlic	9 cloves	8	—	1	—
Ginger	2 tbsp / 30 g	30 g	—	—	—
Kabocha pumpkin	1 lb 2 oz / 500 g whole → 11–12 oz / 300–350 g prepared	all	—	—	—
Limes	3	1	1	$\frac{1}{2}$	$\frac{1}{2}$ (pineapple)
Okra, small pods	5 oz / 150 g	150 g	—	—	—
Onion, brown	2 large	2	—	—	—
Pineapple, ripe	1	—	—	—	1
Red onion	$\frac{1}{4}$	—	$\frac{1}{4}$	—	—
Shallot	1 small	—	—	1	—
Spinach, baby	2 oz / 60 g	60 g	—	—	—
Tomatoes	2 medium	—	2	—	—
PANTRY / DRY					
Chilli flakes (<i>pantry check</i>)	1–2 tsp	✓	—	—	—
Crushed tomatoes	1 lb 12 oz / 800 g	800 g	—	—	—
Ground coriander (<i>pantry check</i>)	2 tsp	✓	—	—	—
Ground cumin (<i>pantry check</i>)	2 tsp	✓	—	—	—
Peanut butter, natural unsweetened	10–11 oz / 280–320 g	all	—	—	—
Peanuts, roasted unsalted	3–3½ oz / 80–100 g	—	—	—	100 g
Rice, long-grain white (<i>pantry check</i>)	7 oz / 200 g	—	—	—	200 g
Tomato paste	2 oz / 60 g	60 g	—	—	—
OILS & LIQUIDS					
Chicken stock	1.8 L / 7½ cups	all	—	—	—
Neutral oil (<i>pantry check</i>)	55 ml	40 ml	—	15 ml	—
Olive oil (<i>pantry check</i>)	1 tbsp	—	1 tbsp	—	—
SEASONING					
Diamond Crystal kosher salt (<i>pantry check</i>)	~20 g across dishes	✓	✓	✓	✓
Flaky sea salt (<i>pantry check</i>)	pinch	—	—	—	✓

Sourcing Notes

- **Buy small okra pods, under 8 cm.** Large pods are woody at the stem and force you to cut through them, which releases the most mucilage.
- One cilantro bunch covers the 20 g.
- Kabocha loses roughly 25% to seeds and stem — hence 500 g whole for 300–350 g prepared.
- Order the chicken from Butcher Box this week rather than assuming counter stock.

1. Chicken Peanut Stew with Kabocha & Okra — 2× Batch

Yield: 6–8 servings (roughly half served, half reserved) · Total: ~115 min · Active: ~45 min · No oven · Hold: see Holding Chain

Rich peanut-tomato braise with staged acidity — tender chicken, kabocha holding its edges, okra with a slight snap at the seed line, glossy sauce, crunchy peanut garnish.

Ingredients

Ingredient	Amount
Bone-in chicken thighs, skin-on	2 lb 10 oz – 3 lb 1 oz / 1.2–1.4 kg
Neutral oil	40 ml / 2¾ tbsp
Onion, diced	2 large
Garlic cloves, minced	8
Fresh ginger, grated	30 ml / 2 tbsp
Tomato paste	2 oz / 60 g / 4 tbsp
Crushed tomatoes	1 lb 12 oz / 800 g
Ground cumin	10 g / 2 tsp
Ground coriander	8 g / 2 tsp
Chilli flakes	2–4 g / 1–2 tsp
Natural peanut butter, unsweetened	10–11 oz / 280–320 g
Chicken stock	1.8 L / 7½ cups (1.5 L added; 300 ml held back)
Diamond Crystal kosher salt	14–18 g (4 g to onions; rest to body)
SERVED HALF ONLY — ADDED AFTER RESERVE DIVERSION	
Kabocha, unpeeled, 3 cm chunks	11–12 oz / 300–350 g prepared
Okra, small pods, caps trimmed, left whole	5 oz / 150 g
Baby spinach	2 oz / 60 g
Fresh cilantro	⅔ oz / 20 g
Lime juice	15–22 ml / 1–1½ tbsp

Salt is computed on edible weight — roughly 900 g from the bone-in figure, plus sauce volume.

Kabocha is unpeeled deliberately. The skin is edible, softens fully, and holds each chunk together — it is the structural reason kabocha survives a braise that would collapse peeled squash.

Okra pods stay whole, cap trimmed without breaching the pod. Mucilage sits inside; every cut surface releases it. Whole pods give vegetal flavour and snap while keeping thickening minimal — which matters, because the peanut emulsion already does that job.

Prep Phase

Pat chicken completely dry. Dice onions; mince garlic; grate ginger. Halve kabocha, scrape seeds, cut into uniform 3 cm chunks with skin on. Trim okra caps without breaching the pod; leave whole. Measure peanut butter separately. Keep the 300 ml reserved stock hot and within reach.

Active Cooking

- 1 Sear, two batches (high).** Heat half the oil until shimmering. Sear batch 1 skin-side down 4–5 min until deeply browned; flip, 2 min. Remove. Repeat with the remaining oil and batch 2. Do not crowd — crowding is the difference between fond and steam at this volume. Remove all skin and discard.
- 2 Aromatic base (medium).** Onions + 4 g salt, 8–10 min until softened with light golden edges. Garlic + ginger, 1 min.
- 3 Tomato development (medium).** Tomato paste 2–3 min until darkened. Cumin, coriander, chilli flakes; bloom 30 sec. Crushed tomatoes 4–5 min, scraping fond off the base.
- 4 Peanut emulsification.** Add 1.5 L stock; bring to a low simmer. Ladle 240 ml / 1 cup hot liquid into the peanut butter and whisk fully smooth before it goes near the pot. Return slowly while stirring.

- 5 Braise (low).** Return chicken. Gentle simmer, partially covered. First check at 25 min, then every 5 min. Chicken remains submerged to service — no formal rest. **Doneness:** flesh alongside the bone separates cleanly under firm thumb pressure → stop. Resists or tears → continue 5 min. Once met, drop to very low, cover, and hold submerged.
- 6 Reserve diversion.** Ladle roughly half the stew — chicken and sauce in proportion — into shallow containers. No vegetables. See the cooling protocol below.
- 7 Kabocha, served half.** Add kabocha. Begin checking after 12 min. **Doneness:** knife tip enters the centre with slight remaining resistance → stop, and take the pot off active heat. Fully yielding → already too far. The cue terminates the heat; the clock does not override it.
- 8 Okra, served half.** Add whole pods 8 minutes after the kabocha. **Doneness:** pod yields to gentle pressure but retains a slight snap at the seed line. If the kabocha cue fires first, the okra comes off with everything else and finishes on residual heat — firm is acceptable, slimy is not.
- 9 Finish.** Spinach 2–3 min, or straight into the pot off heat if the kabocha cue has already fired. Then: lime in 5 ml increments, tasting between — this is where kabocha sweetness gets corrected. Cilantro last, reserving some for plating.

If the sauce reads tight at any point from Step 5 onward: reserved hot stock, 50 ml at a time. Tightening is the expected direction of drift in a wide vessel.

Holding & Assembly — Reserve Cooling

Culinary target: none. This step exists solely for food safety.

Controlling safety requirement. The reserve must move from hot to cold without lingering in the 57–5°C / 135–41°F range. Standard trajectory: down to 21°C / 70°F within two hours, then to 5°C / 41°F within four hours after that.

Method. Divide immediately into shallow containers no deeper than 5 cm. Leave uncovered or loosely covered while cooling — sealing traps heat and defeats the shallow container. Move to the refrigerator promptly; it need not be cold first, and it must not sit until ambient. Cover fully once cold. If the containers are large or the fridge is loaded, use an ice bath.

Food-safety checkpoint (not a culinary CCP). At two hours, the reserve must be at or below 21°C / 70°F. If warmer, accelerate immediately with an ice bath, stirring, and verify the final cooling requirement is still met. If the controlling limit is ultimately exceeded, discard. Consume within 3 days refrigerated, or freeze once cold.

Reheat. Warm gently with a splash of stock. Add freshly cooked kabocha, spinach, lime, and cilantro at that point. Okra optional and best fresh.

Critical Control Points

Class	Failure Mode	Sensory Cue	Recovery
Major	Kabocha collapse — muddy, homogenous body	Chunk edges rounding; definition lost against the spoon	Unrecoverable for the kabocha texture; dish remains serviceable. Prevention is the cue-terminated heat in Step 7
Major	Broken emulsion — greasy, grainy sauce	Oil pooling on the surface, not re-integrating after stirring	Whisk vigorously; add 50 ml hot stock; whisk again. Only if it will not return, whisk fresh peanut butter into cooler liquid separately and reintegrate off heat
Major	Okra over-tendered — slimy texture	Pods fully limp, no resistance at the seed line, visible stringing when lifted	Unrecoverable for the okra; dish remains serviceable. Lift the pods and serve the stew without them
Major	Weak fond from crowded searing — flat, thin stew	Pale chicken surfaces; clean pan base with no browned residue	10–15 ml fish sauce or soy sauce off heat

No Critical CCP remains: every named failure degrades an element while the dish continues to service. The kabocha cue protects eating quality, not the meal itself — which argues against panic if the cue arrives late.

Adjust: salt into the stew body only, never the garnish. Lime in 5 ml increments — expect the upper end against kabocha sweetness. Thin with hot stock, 50 ml at a time. If the stew reads spice-forward rather than peanut-forward, add 30–60 ml stock plus 2 tbsp peanut butter over low heat.

Supporting Dishes · 2–6

Carried forward unchanged from the Recipe Vault and sized for the served meal, not the doubled stew.

2. Steamed Rice

Yield: 4 servings · Total: ~25 min · Active: ~5 min · Hold: 25 min covered off heat

200 g long-grain white rice, 240 ml water, 1 g salt. Rinse until the water runs mostly clear. Combine, bring to a boil, cover, drop to very low for 12–15 min, then rest covered 10 min without lifting the lid. Fluff before serving.

Doneness: chalky centre → continue. Fully tender grain → stop. **Meal-level carve-out:** rice functions as the soft neutral contrast against the rich stew — no internal texture contrast required.

3. Tomato–Cucumber Lime Salad

Yield: 4 servings · Total: ~25 min · Active: ~15 min · Hold: 30 min room temperature

2 medium tomatoes in wedges, 1 medium cucumber unpeeled and thinly sliced, ¼ red onion sliced thin, 22 ml lime juice, 2–3 g salt, 15 ml olive oil optional. Toss and rest 10–15 min. Drain the pooled liquid and re-season with lime and salt immediately before serving.

4. Bird's Eye Chilli Paste

Yield: ~60 ml · Active: ~5 min · Hold: 4 hrs ambient, covered

4–6 bird's eye chillies, 1 small shallot, 1 garlic clove, 1–2 g salt, 15 ml neutral oil, 10–15 ml lime juice. Remove stems; rough-chop shallot and garlic. Pound into a coarse paste, then stir in oil and lime. Do not blend smooth.

Vault notes record this as quite spicy, which is the point: heat is externalised so each diner sets their own level and the stew stays approachable.

5. Crushed Roasted Peanuts

Yield: 80–100 g · Active: ~2 min · Hold: stable in a dry bowl

80–100 g roasted unsalted peanuts, crushed into rough irregular pieces. Do not pulverise. Apply immediately before serving — they soften within 2–3 minutes of contact with the stew.

6. Chilled Pineapple with Lime & Flaky Salt

Yield: 4 servings · Active: ~10 min · Chill: 20–30 min · Hold: 2 hrs chilled

1 ripe pineapple, peeled fully with eyes removed, cut into spears. Toss with 15–22 ml lime juice and chill 20–30 min. Flaky sea salt immediately before serving. Take it out of the fridge 10 minutes ahead if over-chilled — cold mutes the aroma and flattens the finish.

Designed, Not Validated — Log After the Cook

These parameters are engineered for this cook but have never been observed. Record them rather than letting them harden into assumed fact.

#	Parameter	What to Record
1	Kabocha at 15–20 min, 3 cm, unpeeled, in this stew	Time from entry to cue. This determines when the pot comes off heat, so it sets the entry anchor for every future cook of this dish
2	Okra exposure — active and residual	Both figures, and whether firm-at-service was acceptable at the table. This is the one relationship in the timeline that does not close arithmetically, and the acceptable lower bound for whole okra is itself under test
3	2× evaporation in the wide vessel	How much of the 300 ml reserve stock went back in, and at what point
4	Freezer hold for a vegetable-free reserve	Reheat quality. Structurally more plausible than a fully finished stew, but unverified
5	Skin-on sear value	Whether it materially improves the sauce, or whether skin-off-first would be equivalent at less fat
6	Lime multiplicity	Whether four lime uses read as coherent or repetitive across the meal

Cook-Day Cues — Quick Reference

- **Chicken** — flesh separates cleanly from the bone under firm thumb pressure. First check 25 min in.
- **Kabocha** — knife tip enters the centre with slight remaining resistance. This one stops the heat.
- **Okra** — yields to pressure, retains snap at the seed line. Subordinate to the kabocha cue.
- **Lime** — added off heat in 5 ml increments against kabocha sweetness. Expect the upper end of the range.